

BBQ Cook Times Reference Card

Two different numbers matter, and confusing them is how people get sick or serve tough brisket. Safety temperature first, texture temperature second.

1. SAFE MINIMUM INTERNAL TEMPERATURE

These are food safety minimums from USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service. They are not preferences. Measure with a probe in the thickest part, away from bone and fat.

Food	Minimum	Notes
Poultry, all of it	165 F / 74 C	Whole birds, pieces, ground poultry and stuffing. No rest required.
Ground meats	160 F / 71 C	Beef, pork, veal and lamb once ground.
Beef, pork, veal, lamb	145 F / 63 C	Steaks, chops and roasts, PLUS a 3 minute rest before carving.
Fresh or smoked ham, uncooked	145 F / 63 C	Plus a 3 minute rest.
Fully cooked ham, reheating	165 F / 74 C	140 F if it was packaged at a USDA-inspected plant.
Fish and shellfish	145 F / 63 C	Or until flesh is opaque and separates.
Egg dishes	160 F / 71 C	
Leftovers and casseroles	165 F / 74 C	

Source: USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service, Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart. Colour is not doneness. A cooked burger can stay pink and an undercooked one can look brown; only a thermometer tells you.

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Texture, timing and the log.

2. TEXTURE TEMPERATURE, WHICH IS A PREFERENCE

Barbecue pulls tough cuts well past the safety minimum on purpose, because collagen needs time and heat to become gelatine. These are pitmaster convention, not a food safety standard, and the finish is judged by feel more than by number.

Cut	Pit temp	Rough time	Finish by
Brisket, packer	225-250 F	10-16 h	195-205 F, probe slides in like soft butter. Rest 1-2 h.
Pork shoulder / Boston butt	225-275 F	8-14 h	200-205 F for pulling. Rest 1 h minimum.
Pork spare ribs	225-250 F	5-6 h	Bend test: bark cracks when lifted. Roughly 195-203 F.
Baby back ribs	225-250 F	4-5 h	Bend test, same as above.
Beef short ribs	250-275 F	6-8 h	Probe tender, roughly 203 F.
Whole chicken	300-350 F	2-3 h	165 F breast MINIMUM. Higher pit temp for crisp skin.
Chicken thighs	275-325 F	1.5-2 h	Safe at 165 F, but 175-180 F renders better.
Turkey breast	300-325 F	2-3 h	165 F. Do not push it further, it dries.
Pork loin	250 F	2-3 h	145 F plus a 3 minute rest. It is lean, it will not take more.
Salmon	225 F	45-60 min	125-145 F depending on how you like it, 145 F is the safe figure.

Times assume a steady pit and are a planning estimate only. Cook to temperature and feel, never to the clock. Always start earlier than you think; a cooler rests a finished brisket for hours, but nothing rescues one that is not done at dinner time.

THE STALL

Around 150-170 F a large cut stops climbing, sometimes for hours. That is evaporative cooling, not a broken cooker. Wait it out, or wrap in foil or butcher paper to push through. Wrapping is faster and softens bark; waiting keeps bark firmer.

COOK LOG

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DATE	CUT / WEIGHT	PIT TEMP	ON	WRAPPED A	TOFF	FINAL TEMP	REST	WOOD	RESULT